

PREACT 8/9 PRINTABLE PRACTICE EXAM 03 - READING

25 Questions | 30 Minutes

Directions: Choose the best answer for each question. Mark only one answer per question. The answer key and explanations begin after the question section.

PASSAGE 1

Passage:

The Bell Above the Door

Mara had passed Bellini Bicycle Repair every afternoon of her life, but the shop had never looked as narrow as it did with the shades pulled down. Her grandfather had closed it three months earlier after hurting his knee. He still said he was “taking a break,” although dust had begun to soften the outlines of the pumps and wrenches in the window.

For the school’s Main Street history night, Mara’s class was collecting sounds that people remembered: the noon whistle, the click of the old library stamp, the rattle of a delivery cart. Mara wanted the brass bell above the bicycle shop door. It had announced muddy children, serious racers, and parents carrying tiny bikes with bent training wheels.

“Just for one evening,” Mara told her grandfather. “We’ll put it beside a recording of people talking about the shop.”

Grandfather Dario polished his glasses even though they were already clean. “Museums are for things that are finished.” His voice was thin and careful. “That bell still belongs where it is.”

On Saturday, Mara went to help him sort receipts. Inside, the shop smelled of rubber and the lemon oil he used on wooden handles. Grandfather sat behind the counter, placing papers into piles but moving none of them into the empty boxes. Mara decided not to mention the bell. She wiped shelves instead.

Near noon, the door pushed open. The bell gave one bright note, and a boy named Elliot leaned in with his bicycle chain hanging loose. “I know you’re closed,” he said, “but my mom’s at work, and I have to get across town.”

Grandfather was already reaching for his apron. He stopped when his knee met the edge of the counter. Mara brought the bicycle to the repair stand. Following his directions, she loosened the rear wheel, guided the chain back onto its gears, and tightened everything again. Grandfather checked her work with two quick turns of a wrench.

When Elliot rode away, the bell rang a second time. To Mara, it sounded less like an object from the past than the shop waking from a nap.

“What if the exhibit isn’t a museum?” she asked. Her first plan had been to borrow the bell and place it under a sign. Now she described a Saturday repair table in the school courtyard. Grandfather could demonstrate simple fixes from a chair, while Mara and other students did the lifting. They could hang the bell on a wooden frame so each visitor made it ring on arrival. The recording could include new voices as well as old memories.

Grandfather looked toward the door. “A bell needs a door,” he said.

Mara waited.

“So we’ll build it a little one,” he continued. He opened one of the empty boxes, then closed it again. “And on Monday, we put it back here.”

As they measured the doorway, Mara understood that they were not packing the shop away. They were making room for its next use.

R1-001

Why does Grandfather Dario initially refuse to lend the bell?

- A. He doubts that the school can make a clear recording of it.
- B. He worries that displaying it would suggest the shop's story is over.
- C. He wants to sell it to pay for repairs to the shop.
- D. He thinks the bell is too fragile to remove from the doorway.

R1-002

It can reasonably be inferred that Mara decides not to mention the bell while sorting receipts because she:

- A. has already found a different sound for the exhibit.
- B. believes her grandfather has forgotten their earlier conversation.
- C. expects Elliot to arrive and change her grandfather's mind.
- D. recognizes that the subject is emotionally difficult for her grandfather.

R1-003

In the sentence "His voice was thin and careful," the words "thin and careful" most nearly suggest that Grandfather Dario is speaking:

- A. with restrained emotion.
- B. so quietly that Mara cannot hear him.
- C. with playful excitement.
- D. in a hurried and impatient way.

R1-004

What is the main function of the paragraph in which Elliot enters the shop?

- A. It explains why the school chose Main Street as the subject of its event.
- B. It proves that Mara has more repair experience than her grandfather.
- C. It introduces a practical need that reveals the shop can still serve people.
- D. It shows that the shop must reopen immediately as a full-time business.

R1-005

How does Mara's plan for the exhibit change after she repairs Elliot's bicycle?

- A. She decides to replace the bicycle-shop display with a project about the library.
- B. She changes a static display into an event where people can take part in repairs and add new memories.
- C. She decides the bell should remain in the shop and not be included in any form.
- D. She changes the event from a school project into a plan to sell repaired bicycles.

R1-006

Which choice best summarizes the passage?

- A. Mara's effort to borrow a shop bell develops into a plan that honors the shop by continuing its usefulness.
- B. Mara secretly removes a bell, but a visiting customer persuades her to return it.
- C. Grandfather Dario teaches Mara to repair bicycles so that he can retire at once.
- D. A school exhibit fails because Mara and her grandfather disagree about local history.

PASSAGE 2

Passage:

Passage A: The Art of Vanishing

Each spring, volunteers in my neighborhood cover one block of pavement with chalk designs. By evening, the street holds blue whales, family recipes written in looping letters, maps of imaginary cities, and handprints from children who cannot yet write their names. A hard rain may erase the whole display the next day.

Some people ask why artists spend hours making work that will disappear. The question assumes that an artwork's value sits only in the object left behind. Yet the chalk festival is also a public act. A passerby who would never enter a gallery may kneel to add a silver window to someone else's castle. Strangers trade colors and stories. The changing picture records cooperation, even if that record lasts briefly.

Its temporary nature also leaves space for correction and renewal. One year, a design blocked the curb cut used by wheelchairs. The artists noticed the problem, washed away that section, and redrew the path as a river flowing around an open bank. Because no one treated the first version as untouchable, the artwork improved. An empty street the following morning is not proof that the effort failed. It is an invitation to begin again.

Passage B: Keeping the Wall in the Conversation

On the north wall of our community center is a mural painted forty years ago. It shows factory workers, gardeners, musicians, and students gathered around a long table. The factory has since become apartments, and the center's music room has moved twice. Still, residents point to the mural when telling newcomers how the neighborhood sees itself.

The painting has survived because people have accepted custody of it. Custody does not mean sealing the mural away from change. Every few years, students interview longtime residents, study photographs of the original colors, and help conservators clean or repair small areas. During those sessions, people debate what the picture includes and what it leaves out. The care itself becomes a way of examining local history.

Last year, some students proposed painting a new scene over the old one. Instead, the center installed removable panels beside it. The panels now display new artwork about the apartment residents and the bus drivers who begin their routes nearby. This solution does not pretend that the older mural tells the whole story. It allows the old and new images to question each other.

Temporary art can make participation easy, but durable art offers a different gift: a shared object that several generations can revisit. Preservation should not freeze a community's story. At its best, it keeps evidence of an earlier chapter present while the community adds the next one.

R1-007

Which choice best states the central idea of Passage A?

- A. Public art is valuable only when trained artists control its design.
- B. Weather should be prevented from changing outdoor artwork.
- C. Temporary art can be valuable because making and remaking it encourages public participation.
- D. Neighborhood festivals should focus on practical problems instead of art.

R1-008

Which description best characterizes the author's perspective in Passage A?

- A. The author is disappointed that temporary art cannot be sold to museums.
- B. The author is neutral and lists equal arguments for and against chalk art.
- C. The author opposes changing an artwork after its first version is complete.
- D. The author values the shared activity of creating art as much as the finished image.

R1-009

According to Passage B, how does caring for the mural help the community?

- A. It allows residents to avoid discussing changes in the neighborhood.
- B. It gives residents a reason to examine and discuss local history.
- C. It ensures that the mural presents every group in the neighborhood equally.
- D. It teaches students to reproduce the mural without assistance.

R1-010

As used in Passage B, "custody" most nearly means:

- A. responsibility for care.
- B. legal punishment.
- C. private ownership for profit.
- D. freedom from public attention.

R1-011

The passages differ mainly in that Passage A emphasizes:

- A. the cost of public artwork, while Passage B emphasizes who should pay for it.
- B. the accuracy of painted history, while Passage B emphasizes artistic skill.
- C. creation and renewal, while Passage B emphasizes preservation and continued reflection.
- D. children's artwork, while Passage B argues that only adults should make murals.

R1-012

Which pair of details best supports the idea that both authors connect public art with community involvement?

- A. Passage A describes hard rain, and Passage B mentions that the music room moved.
- B. Passage A mentions blue whales, and Passage B describes factory workers in a mural.
- C. Passage A describes an empty street, and Passage B mentions apartments in a former factory.
- D. Passage A shows strangers adding to one design, and Passage B shows students interviewing residents while helping with repairs.

PASSAGE 3

Passage:

The Last Five Minutes

Group discussions often end at their busiest moment. Participants gather evidence, challenge ideas, and then stop when a timer rings. A team of education researchers wondered whether the way a discussion ends affects what students remember and contribute later.

The researchers worked with eighteen after-school clubs for six weeks. Each club had eight to ten students in grades eight and nine. The clubs discussed practical questions, such as how to reduce lunchtime waste or design a quieter study space. The clubs were randomly assigned to one of three routines. In the first routine, students discussed for thirty-five minutes and stopped. In the second, they discussed for thirty minutes, after which the adult facilitator summarized for five minutes. In the third, they also discussed for thirty minutes, but a different student used the final five minutes to summarize each week. The student summarizer had to name the group's main proposal, one piece of supporting evidence, and one question that remained unsettled.

At the start of the next meeting, students completed a brief recall check without looking at notes. They also wrote one possible improvement to the proposal from the previous week. Across the six weeks, students in the no-summary clubs recalled an average of 61 percent of the main points. Those who heard an adult summary recalled 69 percent. Students in the rotating-summary clubs recalled 78 percent and proposed a wider range of improvements.

The numbers did not reveal what students were thinking during the meetings, so the researchers conducted short interviews. Several students in the rotating-summary clubs said they listened for connections because they knew they might have to explain the conversation. One student remarked, "I used to wait for my turn to talk. Now I also notice what I would need to say if I had to wrap up." Even students who were not that week's summarizer reported paying closer attention to disagreements that the group had not resolved.

The researchers cautioned against claiming that a five-minute student summary will improve every discussion. The clubs came from one city, participation was voluntary, and the adult facilitators knew which routine their groups were using. In addition, the study measured recall after one week, not after several months. Still, comparing the two summary routines was useful: both used the same amount of discussion and summary time, but only one required students to organize the group's thinking themselves.

The study suggests that an ending can do more than repeat what has been said. When responsibility for the summary rotates, the final minutes may change how students listen during all the minutes before them.

R1-013

Which choice best states the main idea of the passage?

- A. A rotating student summary may improve both later recall and the attention students give to a group discussion.
- B. Adult facilitators should allow every club discussion to continue beyond its scheduled time.
- C. Students remember practical topics better than they remember academic topics.
- D. Written notes are the only dependable way to measure what students recall.

R1-014

Which result did the researchers observe?

- A. No-summary clubs proposed the widest range of improvements.
- B. Adult-summary clubs recalled 78 percent of the main points.
- C. Rotating-summary clubs had the highest average recall and offered a wider range of improvements.
- D. All three routines produced nearly identical recall scores.

R1-015

What is the main purpose of including the student's remark beginning "I used to wait for my turn to talk"?

- A. To illustrate how the rotating-summary routine may have changed the way students listened.
- B. To show that students disliked proposing improvements to earlier ideas.
- C. To prove that the recall checks were too easy for most students.
- D. To explain why adult facilitators refused to summarize discussions.

R1-016

According to the interviews, why might even students who were not currently summarizing pay closer attention?

- A. They were allowed to see the next week's recall questions in advance.
- B. They wanted to correct errors made by the adult facilitator.
- C. They received extra club credit for identifying every speaker.
- D. They knew they could be responsible for organizing the group's ideas in a future meeting.

R1-017

Which finding most directly supports the claim that organizing the summary oneself matters beyond simply spending five minutes on review?

- A. The rotating-summary groups recalled more than the adult-summary groups even though both used five-minute summaries.
- B. The no-summary groups discussed for thirty-five minutes instead of thirty minutes.
- C. Students discussed topics such as waste and study spaces.
- D. The study measured recall at the start of the following meeting.

R1-018

Which choice best describes the passage's overall structure?

- A. It presents two competing theories, proves both false, and proposes a third theory.
- B. It gives a historical account of clubs before listing rules for starting a new club.
- C. It introduces a research question, explains a study and its results, and then discusses limits and implications.
- D. It describes a student's experience and then argues that statistics should not be used in education research.

PASSAGE 4

Passage:

Small Plants, Milder Weather

High on a windy mountain, many plants grow as low, rounded cushions rather than as tall stems. Their tightly packed leaves trap still air close to the ground. Ecologist Ren Ito wondered whether these cushion plants merely protect themselves or also change conditions for nearby seedlings.

Ito's team selected twenty-four healthy cushion plants on one slope. Beside each cushion, the team marked a patch of bare, rocky soil at the same height and facing the same direction. Tiny sensors recorded temperature and soil moisture in both locations every ten minutes for four weeks. The paired locations let the team compare sites that received similar sunlight and weather.

During clear afternoons, the centers of the cushions were usually cooler than the bare patches. At night, however, they stayed slightly warmer. In other words, the cushions buffered temperature: they reduced the swing between daytime heat and nighttime cold. The soil beneath them also lost moisture more slowly after a light rain.

Next, the team transplanted equal numbers of seedlings from three common mountain species into the centers of cushions, along cushion edges, and into open soil. To separate the effect of shelter from other effects of a living plant, the researchers placed small mesh rings around an additional set of seedlings in open soil. The rings slowed the wind but did not provide shade or add material to the soil.

After eight weeks, two seedling species survived most often at cushion edges. They benefited from milder temperatures without being completely covered by the cushion's leaves. For the third species, survival was nearly the same in mesh rings and at cushion edges, suggesting that reduced wind was especially important for that species. Seedlings placed in cushion centers did not always fare well. Some received too little light, and others had to compete with the cushion plant for water.

The results support calling cushion plants "microclimate engineers" because they alter the small zone around themselves. But the nickname should not be mistaken for a promise that they help every neighbor. A cushion can shelter a seedling from wind, conserve moisture, shade it too deeply, or compete with it. Which effect matters most depends on the seedling species and its exact position.

Ito's study examined one slope during part of one growing season. Longer studies on other mountains would be needed to learn how snow cover, unusually wet years, or different cushion species change the pattern. Even so, the experiment shows why an exposed landscape should not be treated as uniform: a few centimeters can separate a harsh site from a comparatively gentle one.

R1-019

Which choice best states the central idea of the passage?

- A. Cushion plants survive only because other seedlings protect them from mountain winds.
- B. Cushion plants modify nearby conditions, but their effects on seedlings vary by species and position.
- C. Bare rocky soil is always a better location for seedlings than living plants are.
- D. All mountain plants would grow into cushions if they received enough moisture.

R1-020

Why did the researchers place mesh rings around some seedlings in open soil?

- A. To keep the seedlings completely dry after rain.
- B. To reproduce the shade created by cushion leaves.
- C. To mark the seedlings that belonged to the rarest species.
- D. To test the effect of reduced wind without the other effects of a living cushion plant.

R1-021

As used in the passage, “buffered” most nearly means:

- A. made less extreme.
- B. measured incorrectly.
- C. caused to occur earlier.
- D. changed at a steady speed.

R1-022

Which event occurred before the researchers transplanted seedlings?

- A. They studied the influence of snow cover on several mountains.
- B. They concluded that all species survived best in cushion centers.
- C. They recorded temperature and moisture in paired cushion and bare-soil locations.
- D. They removed the cushion plants from the slope.

R1-023

What can reasonably be inferred about measurements taken only during clear afternoons?

- A. They would make cushions appear cooler than bare soil but would miss the cushions’ nighttime warmth.
- B. They would show that cushion centers and bare soil always have identical temperatures.
- C. They would be enough to predict the effects of unusually wet years.
- D. They would prove that wind has no effect on seedlings.

R1-024

What is the main function of the final paragraph?

- A. To introduce a new experiment that contradicts all the earlier results.
- B. To argue that the sensors should have been placed farther apart.
- C. To explain why the team selected only tall plants for the study.
- D. To identify limits on the study’s scope while explaining the broader significance of its findings.

R1-025

Which choice best summarizes the study's findings?

- A. Cushion centers provided the best conditions for every seedling because they had the most shade.
- B. Mesh rings changed soil moisture and light in exactly the same ways as cushion plants.
- C. Cushions created milder local conditions, yet shelter, shade, and competition affected seedling species differently.
- D. Open soil stayed warmer at night and wetter after rain than cushion locations did.

ANSWER KEY + EXPLANATIONS

Each explanation corresponds to the numbered question in the practice section.

R1-001 - Correct: B. He worries that displaying it would suggest the shop's story is over.

Explanation: Grandfather says museums are for things that are finished and insists the bell still belongs in the shop. His response shows that he fears the display would treat the shop as a completed chapter.

R1-002 - Correct: D. recognizes that the subject is emotionally difficult for her grandfather.

Explanation: After seeing that he moves no papers into the boxes and reacts carefully to the bell request, Mara avoids raising the subject again. These details show that she recognizes his discomfort.

R1-003 - Correct: A. with restrained emotion.

Explanation: Grandfather polishes already-clean glasses and responds indirectly, so the phrase describes controlled, restrained emotion rather than a problem with volume.

R1-004 - Correct: C. It introduces a practical need that reveals the shop can still serve people.

Explanation: Elliot's loose chain gives Mara and her grandfather a real repair to complete. The incident demonstrates that the shop's skills and tools still have a present use.

R1-005 - Correct: B. She changes a static display into an event where people can take part in repairs and add new memories.

Explanation: Before the repair, Mara plans to display the bell with a recording. Afterward, she proposes a repair table where visitors ring the bell and help create new memories.

R1-006 - Correct: A. Mara's effort to borrow a shop bell develops into a plan that honors the shop by continuing its usefulness.

Explanation: The passage begins with Mara seeking a historical object and ends with a participatory repair event. The new plan respects the shop's history by putting its purpose back into action.

R1-007 - Correct: C. Temporary art can be valuable because making and remaking it encourages public participation.

Explanation: Passage A argues that chalk art matters through cooperation, correction, and renewal even when the image disappears.

R1-008 - Correct: D. The author values the shared activity of creating art as much as the finished image.

Explanation: The author calls the festival a public act and describes strangers adding to one another's work. These details show that the shared process is central to the author's view of value.

R1-009 - Correct: B. It gives residents a reason to examine and discuss local history.

Explanation: Passage B states that interviews, research, cleaning, and repair lead people to debate what the mural includes and omits, making care a way to examine history.

R1-010 - Correct: A. responsibility for care.

Explanation: The community accepts ongoing responsibility to clean, repair, and discuss the mural, so "custody" means responsibility for its care.

R1-011 - Correct: C. creation and renewal, while Passage B emphasizes preservation and continued reflection.

Explanation: Passage A focuses on a temporary image that can be revised and begun again. Passage B focuses on maintaining an older mural so generations can revisit and question it.

R1-012 - Correct: D. Passage A shows strangers adding to one design, and Passage B shows students interviewing residents while helping with repairs.

Explanation: The details in this choice show people actively shaping or caring for the art in both passages, directly linking the artwork to community participation.

R1-013 - Correct: A. A rotating student summary may improve both later recall and the attention students give to a group discussion.

Explanation: The rotating-summary groups had the strongest recall and more varied improvements, while interviews suggest that possible responsibility for summarizing changed how students listened.

R1-014 - Correct: C. Rotating-summary clubs had the highest average recall and offered a wider range of improvements.

Explanation: The passage reports 78 percent average recall and a wider range of improvements for the rotating-summary groups, both higher than the outcomes described for the other routines.

R1-015 - Correct: A. To illustrate how the rotating-summary routine may have changed the way students listened.

Explanation: The student contrasts waiting to speak with noticing what would be needed to wrap up the discussion. The remark illustrates the listening change suggested by the interview results.

R1-016 - Correct: D. They knew they could be responsible for organizing the group's ideas in a future meeting.

Explanation: Students said they listened for connections because they knew they might need to explain the discussion. Rotating responsibility made a future turn as summarizer possible.

R1-017 - Correct: A. The rotating-summary groups recalled more than the adult-summary groups even though both used five-minute summaries.

Explanation: Both groups had thirty minutes of discussion and five minutes of summary, but recall was higher when a student summarized. That comparison isolates who organized the review as the key difference.

R1-018 - Correct: C. It introduces a research question, explains a study and its results, and then discusses limits and implications.

Explanation: The passage moves from the researchers' question to the three routines, reports quantitative and interview results, and closes with cautions and implications.

R1-019 - Correct: B. Cushion plants modify nearby conditions, but their effects on seedlings vary by species and position.

Explanation: Sensors showed that cushions reduced temperature swings and slowed moisture loss, but the transplant results differed according to seedling species and location.

R1-020 - Correct: D. To test the effect of reduced wind without the other effects of a living cushion plant.

Explanation: The passage explicitly says the mesh rings slowed wind without adding shade or soil material. This allowed reduced wind to be examined separately from other cushion effects.

R1-021 - Correct: A. made less extreme.

Explanation: The cushions reduced the swing between afternoon heat and nighttime cold, so "buffered" means made less extreme.

R1-022 - Correct: C. They recorded temperature and moisture in paired cushion and bare-soil locations.

Explanation: The sensors recorded temperature and moisture for four weeks before the passage says, "Next, the team transplanted" the seedlings.

R1-023 - Correct: A. They would make cushions appear cooler than bare soil but would miss the cushions' nighttime warmth.

Explanation: The passage reports cooler cushion centers during clear afternoons but slightly warmer ones at night. Afternoon-only data would therefore omit part of the temperature pattern.

R1-024 - Correct: D. To identify limits on the study's scope while explaining the broader significance of its findings.

Explanation: The final paragraph notes that the study covered one slope and part of one season, then explains that small distances can create meaningfully different conditions.

R1-025 - Correct: C. Cushions created milder local conditions, yet shelter, shade, and competition affected seedling species differently.

Explanation: The study found milder temperatures and slower moisture loss near cushions, but it also found different outcomes from wind shelter, shade, and competition across species and positions.